illegal logging, mining, oil extraction, dam construction and infrastructure development. Let us study about some of them in this section.

a. Agricultural Expansion

With increasing population, there is an overgrowing demand for food production. Hence, large amount of trees are chopped down for crop production and for cattle grazing. More than 40% of the forests are cleaned to obtain land and to meet the needs of agriculture.

b. Urbanization

With the expansion of cities more land is needed to establish housing and settlement. Requirements like construction of roads, development of houses, mineral exploitation and expansion of industries also arise due to urbanisation. Forests are destroyed to meet all these needs.

c. Mining

Mining of coal, diamond and gold require a large amount of forest land. So, a large number of trees is cut down to clear the forest area. Moreover, the waste that comes out from mining pollutes the environment and affects the nearby plants.

d. Construction of dams

To provide water supply to the increasing population, large size dams are constructed. Hence, a great extend of forest area is being cleared.



Figure 22.1 Dam

e. Timber Production

We need wood to meet the needs of our daily life. Wood-based industries like paper, match-sticks, furniture need a substantial amount of wood supply. Wood is the most commonly used fuel. Thus, a large number of trees are being cut down for fuel supplies. Some people are involved in illegal wood cutting and destroy more number of trees. This is the main reason for the destruction of some valuable plants.



Figure 22.2 Destruction of trees

DO YOU KNOW?

Chipko Movement is primarily a forest conservation movement. The word 'Chipko' means 'to stick' or 'to hug'. Sunderlal Bahuguna was the founder of this movement. It was started in 1970s with the aim of protecting and conserving trees and preserving forest from being destroyed.



f. Forest fire

In many forests, fires are usually expected from time to time. They may be caused by humans, accidents or natural factors. Forest fires wipe out thousands of acres of forest land each year all over the world. This has tremendous effects on biodiversity and the economy as well.



Figure 22.3 Forest fire

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